

SOP: IT Helpdesk Incident Escalation

Clearwave Technologies, Inc. — IT Service Management

Document ID	SOP-IT-014	Version	1.5
Effective Date	July 1, 2024	Owner	IT Service Management

1. Purpose and Scope

This Standard Operating Procedure defines how the IT Helpdesk classifies, escalates, and resolves reported incidents, from an individual user's login issue to a company-wide system outage. It applies to all Tier 1, Tier 2, and Tier 3 support staff.

2. Severity Definitions and Targets

Severity	Description	Response Time	Resolution Target
Sev 1 – Critical	System down; all users affected	15 minutes	4 hours
Sev 2 – High	Major feature broken; many users affected	1 hour	8 business hours
Sev 3 – Medium	Issue has a workaround	4 business hours	3 business days
Sev 4 – Low	Cosmetic or minor issue	1 business day	10 business days

If a Sev 1 incident is not resolved within 2 hours of initial report, it must be automatically escalated to the IT Director.

3. Escalation Path

Tier 1 Helpdesk → Tier 2 Systems Engineer → Tier 3 Senior Engineer / Vendor Support → IT Director. Each tier must attempt resolution within its allotted response window before escalating further.

4. Step-by-Step Procedure

- Step 1: Log the incident in TicketDesk immediately upon report, capturing affected systems and number of users impacted.
- Step 2: Classify severity using the table in Section 2.
- Step 3: Tier 1 attempts initial triage and resolution using the internal knowledge base.
- Step 4: If unresolved at 80% of the response time window, escalate to the next tier.
- Step 5: For Sev 1 and Sev 2 incidents, post a status update to the internal status page and notify affected department leads.
- Step 6: Upon resolution, document root cause and remediation steps in the ticket.
- Step 7: For every Sev 1 incident, conduct a blameless post-incident review within 5 business days of resolution.

5. Communication Cadence

- Sev 1: status update every 30 minutes until resolved.
- Sev 2: status update every hour until resolved.
- Sev 3 and Sev 4: status update upon any material change, or at minimum once per business day.

6. Roles and Responsibilities

- Tier 1 Helpdesk: initial triage, classification, and first-line resolution.
- Tier 2 Systems Engineer: deeper technical investigation and infrastructure-level fixes.
- Tier 3 Senior Engineer / Vendor: root-cause resolution for complex or vendor-dependent issues.
- IT Director: executive communication and resourcing decisions for unresolved Sev 1 incidents.